



Consent

Helps Everyone Feel Safe



Dear kids,

Adults sometimes use the word “safe” to describe what we do with our hands, because not all kids feel safe when they're touched by someone else, like through a hug, hand holding, or a high five.



Kids might not feel safe when they're touched for several reasons. They might not like the way that it feels, they might be shy or nervous, or they might just not feel ready.



Here are two words that might help you better understand:



Consent:

This is permission for something to happen. Your friend should give you consent to physical touch before you touch them.



Boundary:

This means limit. By saying no to a hug, your friend is setting a boundary that makes them feel safe.

Here are some things you can do to make sure that your friends always feel safe and respected around you.

1 Ask first.

Before touching a new friend, ask them if they're okay with it.



2 Offer alternatives.

If your friend says no, ask what might help them feel safe. For example, if they don't want a hug, maybe they'd like a high five? A handshake? A wave? An adult can help you come up with some good options!



3 Watch for body language.

If you've already given a friend a hug, it's okay! Try to think about how their body reacted to that gesture. Was it stiff? Did they keep their arms at their side? Was their face happy or sad? Body language can tell you a lot about how a person is feeling. Ask an adult for help understanding!



4 Don't be sad!

Just because someone says they don't want to be touched doesn't mean they don't like you, or that they don't want to be your friend. Each person is unique, and we're all comfortable with different things.



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